



THROUGHOUT THE 1990s AND 2000s, THE MCC-MURUGAPPA GOLD CUP CONTINUED TO THRIVE, UNEARTHING NUMEROUS PLAYERS WHO WENT ON TO REPRESENT INDIA IN WORLD CUPS AND OLYMPICS

Promotion Board (RSPB), the defending champion, overcame a spirited comeback by Indian Oil Corporation Limited (IOCL) to win the final 5-3.

The roots of the Gold Cup stretch back to 1901, when the Madras Cricket Club inaugurated the Madras Challenge Cup at the Tamil Nadu Cricket Association (TNCA) grounds. In 1962, the Murugappa group launched a separate hockey tournament, the Murugappa Gold Cup Championship, which was played in Egmore. These two competitions merged in 1996 to form a single invitational tournament, ensuring that the finest teams from across the country would participate in Chennai's celebration of the national sport.

"I played here [Egmore stadium] at a very young age when it was still the Murugappa Gold Cup," said V. Baskaran, captain of India's 1980 Olympic gold medal-winning team. "There were temporary stands on one side and a cement stand on the other."

"I also played the MCC tournament at the centre pitch of the TNCA grounds," he reminisced. "There was a large gallery adjacent to the pitch, and the ground had lush grass maintained to world-class standards for a month."

Alongside Baskaran, several Indian hockey legends from the dominant teams of the 1960s and 70s — such as Udham Singh, Gurbux Singh, V.J. Peter, Prithipal Singh, and Vijay Phillips — showcased their skills

Retaining the crown: The Railway Sports Promotion Board (RSPB), the defending champion, overcame a spirited comeback by Indian Oil Corporation Limited (IOCL) to win the final 5-3. M. VEDHAN

in this tournament.

Throughout the 1990s and 2000s, the tournament continued to thrive, unearthing numerous players who went on to represent India in World Cups and Olympics. Many of them remain involved, either as players or in coaching roles. "As a child, when we learned about the domestic circuit and the key tournaments to make an impact in the big league

and catch the eye of selectors and coaches, this was the one," said RSPB's Yuvraj Walmiki, who represented India at the 2014 World Cup. The forward from Mumbai was named the best forward in the league for the second consecutive year.

"This is one of the top-grade tournaments in the country," added V.R. Raghunath, a two-time Olympian. "It's the first tournament of the season, so the best players participate, and the teams are at their peak fitness. It's one of the most celebrated events in domestic hockey."

Despite its glorious past, domestic tournaments like the Murugappa Gold Cup have witnessed a significant decline in spectator turnout. The once-packed stadium now sees only a few hundred in